

Wild Bergamot

Monarda fistulosa

Bee Balm · Horsemint



QUALITIES

A clumping mint-family perennial 2 to 4 feet tall, with square stems, opposite gray-green leaves that smell sharply of oregano when bruised, and rounded two-inch-wide pom-poms of lavender-pink tubular flowers in July. Flowers persist three to four weeks; the structural seedheads remain handsome through fall and into winter. Forms a slowly-expanding colony by underground rhizomes.

CARE

Full sun is best; tolerates light shade. Average to dry soil; drought-tolerant. Deer-resistant. In humid climates or crowded plantings, watch for powdery mildew on lower leaves; thinning the clump and improving airflow usually fixes it without spraying. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Cut back to 6 inches in late winter; the hollow stems (*fistulosa* means "hollow") house overwintering native bees, so don't tidy too early in spring.

HISTORY

Wild bergamot is the wild ancestor of cultivated Bee Balm and is named for its similarity in scent to bergamot orange (*Citrus bergamia*) — Earl Grey tea's flavor note. The Ojibwe and Menominee used the leaves as a medicinal tea for respiratory illness, and the species is the primary source of thymol in pre-aspirin North American medicine. Following the Boston Tea Party, colonists used wild bergamot as a black-tea substitute ("Oswego tea").

REASON TO BE

If you plant only one pollinator forb, plant this. Wild bergamot draws an extraordinary diversity of visitors: long-tongued native bumblebees, Hummingbird Clearwing moths, Ruby-throated Hummingbirds, Eastern Tiger Swallowtails, and dozens of native bee species. Its hollow stems shelter overwintering tunnel-nesting bees. It is a workhorse that delivers ecological value at every stage — bloom, seed, winter cover.